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DRAFT TRAILS PLAN

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Introduction

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A critical component of the state trails planning process is an ongoing effort to develop a comprehensive inventory of existing, planned and proposed trails in the state.

This process has enabled ODNR to begin developing Geographic Information System (GIS) based maps that will assist agencies and organizations in trail planning efforts and help establish the basis for a statewide trails vision.

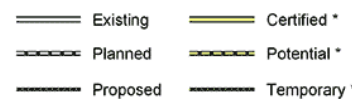
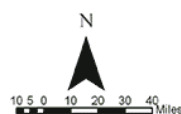
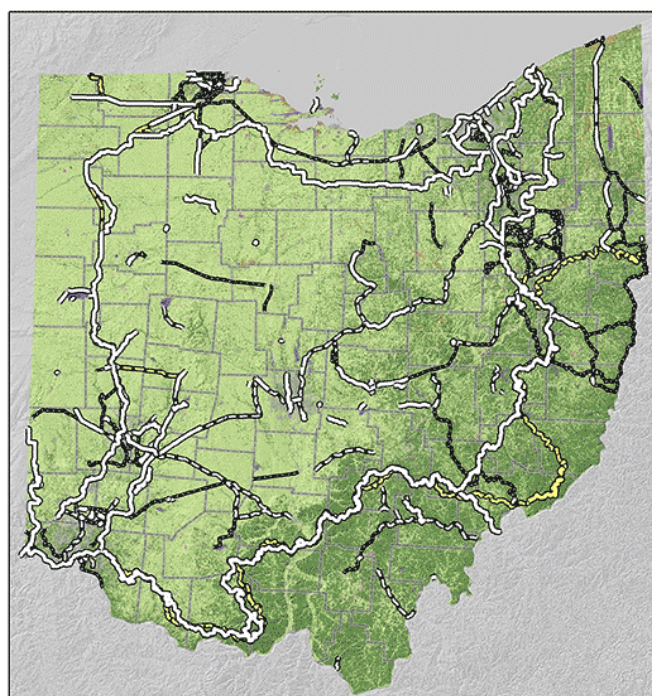
Trail corridors in this plan are categorized and color-coded in three ways: existing; planned; and potential.

For purposes of definition, existing trails in this plan are those that are available for public use and are being actively managed and maintained by an agency or trail organization.

Planned trails are corridors that are not yet open for use but are in some formal stage of planning, have been identified in a trails plan, or are actively being considered for trail development.

An example of a planned trail would be a railroad corridor that is owned by a public agency but has not yet been developed or a corridor that has not yet been acquired but there are active efforts (e.g. a grant proposal has been submitted) by an agency to secure a right-of-way.

A proposed trail is more conceptual in nature than a planned trail. It could be an abandoned railroad or a utility corridor that no public agency is actively pursuing but has the potential to some day be developed into a trail. There no doubt will be some inconsistencies in this identification system, especially when attempting to make precise differentiations between planned and proposed trails.



* North Country Trail Designations

Trail Names

The concept of a trail name seems simple enough. Nevertheless, many individual trails might actually be part of a larger system and consequently could be referred to in a number of ways. A good example is ODNR's 44+ mile Little Miami Scenic Park (LMSP) in southwestern Ohio. The LMSP is a popular rail-trail that is also a component of the North Country National Scenic Trail, the Buckeye Trail, and the Ohio to Erie Trail. Trails that are part of a larger trail system (and have multiple names) create logistical identification problems on regional maps. As a result, the maps might not necessarily identify all of the possible trail names on each segment of a trail.

Trail Classifications

For planning and identification purposes, trail corridors have been further categorized into five classifications in this document:

- national
- state
- regional
- countywide
- community based trails

National trails are either dedicated components of the National Trails System or are actively being considered for such status. Statewide trails are of sufficient distance and scope that they traverse and impact numerous regions in the state. Regional trails are those that are located in multiple counties or are planned for multi-county areas. Countywide trails are those that are, for the most part, outside of local jurisdictions but stay within the geographic boundary of one county. Community trails are confined to a specific local jurisdiction but could connect or have the potential to connect to larger systems.

Again, this classification system is not perfect, but is an attempt to provide meaningful differentiation among a wide variety of trail systems. Trails in these five categories are identified on the various maps in this plan using the following numbering system: national trails-1000s; statewide trails-2000s; regional trails-3000s; countywide trails-4000s; and community based trails-5000s.

NATIONAL TRAILS

There are two national trails that pass through Ohio, the North Country National Scenic Trail and the American Discovery Trail. A third trail, the Underground Railroad, is included because of its status as a National Millennium Trail.

North Country National Scenic Trail

In March 1980, the North Country National Scenic Trail (NCNST) was officially authorized when Congress passed and President Carter signed legislation (PL 96-199) that ultimately added eight new national scenic trails to the National Trails System. The concept of a "north country trail" was first proposed by the U.S. Forest Service in its 1965 "Nationwide System of Trails Study". It was called the "Northern Country Trail" in that report and was included in the 1966 Department of the Interior publication entitled "Trails for America." This report set the stage for the passage of the National Trails System Act in 1968. The name of the proposed route was changed to "North Country Trail" in that report.

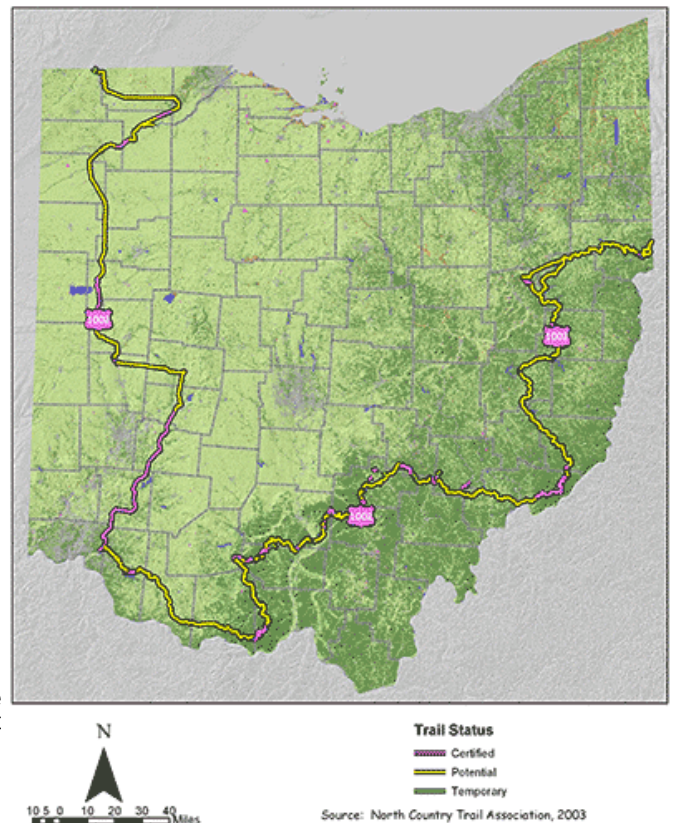
When Congress passed the National Trails System Act in 1968, two trails – the Appalachian and Pacific Crest – were immediately designated as National Scenic Trails. Fourteen other trail routes were named for study as potential additions to the system. The North Country Trail was one of those 14 potential trail routes.

A diverse, multi-agency planning committee completed a conceptual study in 1975 that identified a 10-mile wide corridor in which the trail route could ultimately be located. In 1982, the National Park Service adopted a Comprehensive Plan for Management and Use of the North Country Trail that gave several key directions to the trail, including the vision as a non-motorized, multi-use pedestrian trail. Today, the NCNST is a 4,100+ mile trail that crosses seven states from New York to North Dakota. Approximately 1,050 potential miles of the trail pass through Ohio.

The North Country Trail makes a u-shaped sweep through Ohio. It enters the state from Pennsylvania near Negley (Columbiana County) on a former railroad corridor and to passes through a diverse array of public and private lands and scenic/historic areas. It leaves the state in northwestern Ohio (into Michigan). For much of its route, the NCNST follows the Buckeye Trail, although significant sections do diverge from the Buckeye Trail or are planned to in various locations.

While more than 1,000 miles of the North Country Trail pass through Ohio, to date only 320 miles (approximately 30 percent) are "certified". Certified sections are essentially segments that are managed in accordance with the policies of the "Comprehensive Plan for Management and Use" and the responsible managing agency/authority has granted permission to certify the trail as an official segment of the North Country Trail. Many more miles of uncertified segments are usable and open for public use.

The National Park Service (NSP) administers the North Country Trail in cooperation with other government agencies, private organizations, and individual landowners. NPS's responsibilities include: ensuring the development, protection, and maintenance of the trail; coordinating the activities of the many partners in the trail's development/management; and providing technical and financial assistance to



cooperating interests. Because numerous public agencies and private interests are participating in the NCNST's development, the type of trail, available support facilities, and rules and regulations governing the use of the trail varies from segment to segment.

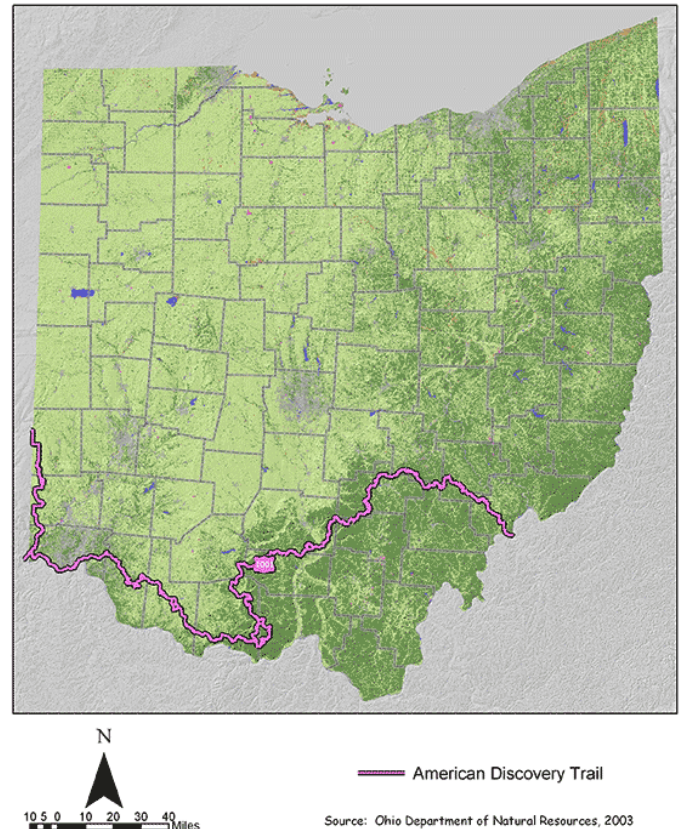
The North Country Trail Association (NCTA) is a neutral non-profit organization that works in partnership with the National Park Service to build, maintain and promote the North Country Trail. The NCTA works through a national network of volunteers, chapters, partner organizations and government agencies to accomplish its missions.

American Discovery Trail

The American Discovery Trail (ADT) is the nation's first coast-to-coast, non-motorized trail that stretches approximately 6,800 miles from Delaware to California. The ADT is proposed as a new breed of national trail, linking communities, urban areas, and backcountry to serve as the backbone of the national trails system. Although a person can walk or ride the entire ADT today, Congress is considering legislation that would make the ADT a designated component of the national trails system.

The ADT enters Ohio from the west along two routes, converges just west of Cincinnati and exits Ohio near Belpre (Washington County) into West Virginia. The ADT routes in Ohio total approximately 510 miles. Like the North Country National Scenic Trail, the ADT follows the Buckeye Trail through much of its route in Ohio (from Chesterhill in Morgan County to Eden Park in Cincinnati) and uses many of the least traveled public roads to connect to off road sections.

The American Discovery Trail Society, a nationwide non-profit organization, administers the affairs of the ADT and coordinates the efforts of the many agencies and organizations that manage and maintain the trail. Each state through which the ADT passes also has a state coordinator who oversees ADT trail development and issues in that particular state.



The Underground Railroad, A National Millennium Trail

The Underground Railroad is neither "underground" nor a "railroad" but rather a cultural trail representing a network of sites, routes and events that tell the story of the thousands of people who escaped from slavery and those who assisted them in their pursuit of freedom. Underground Railroad activities covered all of the states in the eastern half of the United States, as well as Canada, Mexico, and the Caribbean.

Ohio was an especially important Underground Railroad state since the Ohio River separated it from the slave-owning states of Kentucky and Virginia (now West Virginia); and Lake Erie separated it from Canada, the final destination for many runaway slaves. As a result, Ohio is particularly rich in Underground Railroad resources. To date, over 800 Underground Railroad sites have been researched and documented statewide and it is likely that hundreds more will be found in the future. The Underground Railroad represents an important story in American and Ohio history.

The Friends of Freedom Society, Inc. (FOFS) and the Ohio Underground Railroad Association (the "research arm" of FOFS) is a grassroots, all volunteer non-profit organization dedicated to the research, identification, documentation and preservation of Underground Railroad sites in Ohio. The FOFS was the driving force to get the Underground Railroad designated as one of the nation's sixteen National Millennium Trails, visionary trails that reflect defining aspects in America's history and culture.

STATEWIDE TRAILS

This plan recognizes two statewide trails, the Buckeye Trail and the Ohio to Erie Trail. Both are long distance trails that are statewide in scope and impact.

Buckeye Trail

The Buckeye Trail winds for nearly 1,300 miles and reaches into every corner of Ohio. First envisioned in the late 1950s as a trail that would link the Ohio River to Lake Erie, the Buckeye Trail eventually

evolved into a large loop, branching both north and east from Cincinnati. The separate routes now rejoin in the Cuyahoga Valley National Park south of Cleveland and complete the connection to Lake Erie.

The Buckeye Trail follows old canal towpaths, abandoned railroads, rivers, lakes, rural roadways, and numerous footpaths through both public and private lands. It passes through many state and local parks, state and national forests, small towns and urban areas alike.

The trail is administered and maintained by the Buckeye Trail Association (BTA), a non-profit volunteer organization, in partnership with numerous public agencies and private landowners. The Ohio Department of Natural Resources, the Ohio Historical Society, the U.S. Forest Service (Wayne National Forest), Muskingum and Miami

Conservancy districts, and various metropolitan park districts and private landowners are active partners in the Buckeye Trail. The BTA has developed a series of detailed maps for 24 sections of the Buckeye Trail. To view or order these maps, go to the BTA website, www.buckeyetrail.org. In the field, blue blazes are used to identify the Buckeye Trail.

While the Buckeye Trail does wind its way through numerous public and private lands, much of it is located on low use county and township roads. The goal of the Buckeye Trail Association is to eventually have the entire route of the trail off roads, but this will take a long time to accomplish. The Buckeye Trail is primarily a footpath although portions are usable for bicycling and horseback riding.

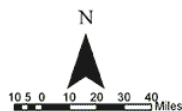
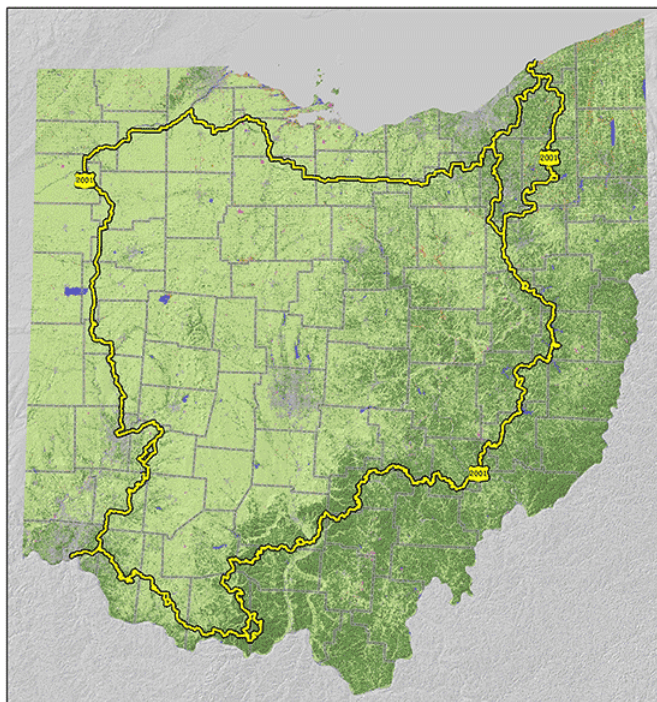
The Buckeye Trail is also recognized as Ohio's only State Legacy Trail, a national program that was developed to call attention to the nation's rail-trails and greenways, historic trails, cultural itineraries, recreation paths, waterways, and other alternative transportation corridors.

Ohio to Erie Trail

The Ohio to Erie Trail (OET) was envisioned in the early 1990s as the backbone of an interconnecting system of trails from the Ohio River to Lake Erie. When completed, the OET will be a mostly paved multi-purpose trail linking Cincinnati, Columbus and Cleveland following lands occupied by railroads and canals. In addition to connecting three of Ohio's major cities, the OET will pass through quiet woods, lush agricultural lands and numerous small towns along its 473-mile route. In central Ohio, the OET breaks into two routes, the Heart of Ohio Trail and Panhandle Trail, before joining again in northeast Ohio.

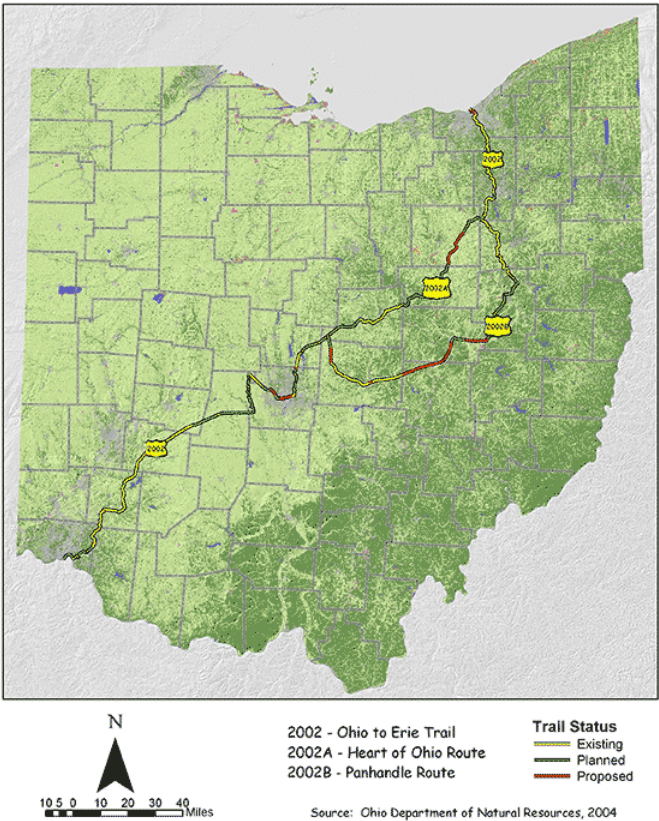
To date, more than 220 miles of the OET has been developed and are open to the public (approximately 47 percent of the total 473 miles). There are, however, major sections of the OET that still must be acquired and developed or where the actual trail location must still be finalized. Approximately 147 miles of right-of-way must still be acquired to complete the acquisition phase of the OET and another 250 miles of the OET still must be developed.

The Ohio to Erie Trail Fund (OETF) was



— Buckeye Trail

Source: Buckeye Trail Association, 2003



established in 1991 to oversee the development of the OET. Its primary mission is to build the OET by raising money to purchase land when no government agency is willing or able to make the acquisition vital to the trail's completion. OETF receives donations from numerous corporations, organizations, and individuals to finance its operation.

The OETF works closely with government agencies and trail groups that are building and maintaining the OET. Numerous government agencies (as many as 30-40) could be involved with developing and managing sections of the OET when it is completed. In addition, OETF works with private landowners and railroads to secure rights-of-way for the OET. The OETF is actively seeking funding from the Ohio General Assembly (capital budget earmarks) and the U.S. Congress (federal transportation legislation earmarks) to build the trail.

The Ohio to Erie Trail Fund has identified a number of high priority areas for acquisition and development. These priorities are listed below starting from the southern leg of the trail in Cincinnati.

1. Sawyer Point (Cincinnati riverfront) through the Village of Terrace Park. This section includes the "Ohio River Trail" along the Ohio River from downtown Cincinnati through Anderson Township and eventually connecting to the Little Miami Scenic Park, the Ohio Department of Natural Resources' (ODNR) 45-mile rail-trail state park. The Hamilton County Park District, Anderson Township, and ODNR will be key players in getting this section completed.
2. Columbus Area. Getting the OET through/around Columbus has been a challenge since the trail was initially conceived. Key sections that must be addressed are in the Hilliard area (which requires acquisition from Norfolk and Southern Railroad), getting the trail across town through the Arena District and Ross Lab land, and then north of Ohio Dominican College (Leonard Avenue) to Morse Road. Sections of the trail along Alum Creek north of Morse Road are scheduled for development by Columbus and Westerville.
3. Delaware County. Portions of the OET in Delaware County are completed, however, the section from Galena through Sunbury to Condit is a priority for development. The city of Columbus and Preservation Parks of Delaware County are key local agencies in completing these sections.
4. Knox/Licking County line just southwest of Centerburg to Mt. Vernon. ODOT has committed Transportation Enhancement funds for acquiring 15.6 miles of right of way. Development funds will eventually be needed to build this section.
5. The entire right-of-way through Holmes County is in public ownership, however, the southern section from Brinkhaven to Killbuck needs funding for development. Both ODNR and ODOT have committed development funds for a section in northern Holmes County (approximately 10 miles from Millersburg north to Fredricksburg in southern Wayne County).
6. Approximately 9.8 miles of right-of-way must be acquired in the area of Orrville to Clinton.
7. Cleveland Section. Like Cincinnati and Columbus, completing the trail through Cleveland presents many challenges. The trail needs to be developed from Harvard Avenue north into the Flats area then connect to the Lakefront Bikeway. The Cuyahoga County Planning Commission (CCPC), in cooperation with numerous other partners in northeastern Ohio, has developed a conceptual plan for completing this section of trail.

8. Panhandle Section. Approximately 10 miles in Tuscarawas County from Newcomerstown to Stone Creek needs development funds, including approximately \$300,000 for tunnel renovation near Stone Creek.

REGIONAL ASSESSMENTS

To get a better perspective of Ohio's trails, the system is reviewed on a regional basis- using the five tourism regions adopted by the Ohio Department of Development's Division of Travel and Tourism. The format for each assessment includes a brief regional overview, references to the major trail systems, and some discussion on a county basis where extensive trail planning and/or development has taken place.

The inventory of trails data to follow was compiled from a variety of sources including public meetings, various publications and websites, trail managers, and applications for ODNR administered grant programs. Trails other than those portrayed on the regional maps are still considered part of a statewide system, especially if they emphasize or provide links. The trails featured in this plan focus on those that are located outside of traditional parks, forests, or other lands (although some of the trails do pass through these lands). Loop trails, perimeter trails, and similar recreational trails contained within a "park" boundary are not included in this plan. These types of trails certainly are components of the state trail system, provide valuable outdoor recreation opportunities, and sometimes even link to larger trail systems. Nevertheless, the focus of this plan is the development of an interconnected system of recreational trails and most of those are outside traditional parks.

Maintaining an up-to-date inventory of existing, planned and proposed trails requires it be ever-changing, requiring constant revision as new trails are introduced into the system. Information on both existing and planned trails should be submitted to the Ohio Department of Natural Resources, Division of Real Estate and Land Management for inclusion in the inventory.

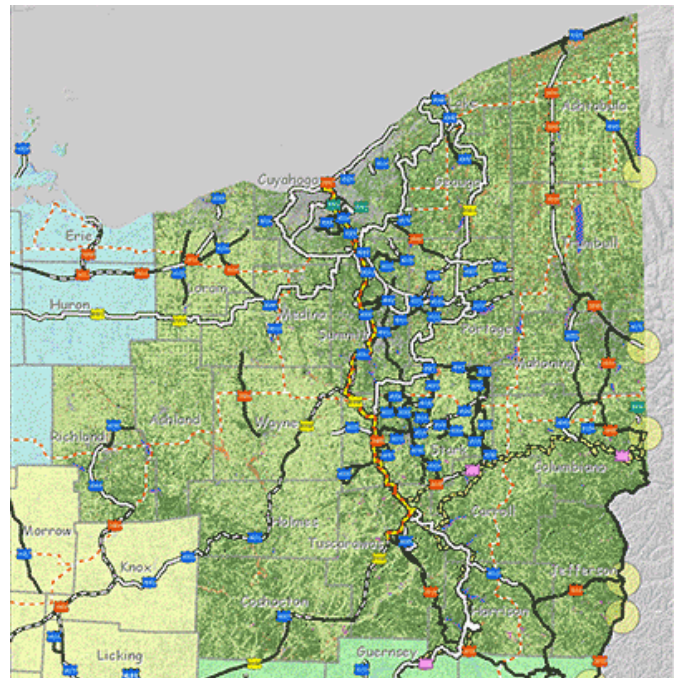
NORTHEAST OHIO

Overview

Northeast Ohio has one of the most well planned and extensive systems of recreational trails in Ohio. Northeast Ohio is the home of the Ohio & Erie Canal National Heritage Canalway and the Cuyahoga Valley National Park (CVNP). The national park's Towpath Trail is considered the spine of the canal way. Cleveland Metroparks' "Emerald Necklace" is a national model of one of the earliest efforts to develop a system of linear, interconnected parks. A lakefront bikeway is being planned by a partnership of government agencies and private interests. The North Country National Scenic Trail enters the state from Pennsylvania in northeastern Ohio and significant portions of the Buckeye Trail and the Ohio to Erie Trail also span this region.

Figure 5.6

The Northeast Ohio Regional Parks Consortium has been studying opportunities for linking existing parks and protecting river corridors for an eight county portion of northeastern Ohio. The consortium developed a conceptual plan where more than 1,000 miles of new trails could be constructed in this region. In addition, a number of county and community trail plans have been completed in northeast Ohio. Public land managing agencies are successfully planning, acquiring, and developing numerous trails that connect communities, provide close to home recreation, and serve as destinations for others.



Cuyahoga County

There are about 15 miles of interconnecting trails within Cuyahoga County, according to the Cuyahoga County Greenspace Plan. The extension of the Towpath Trail into the Cuyahoga Valley and the Flats, the completion of the Lakefront Bikeway, and the continued expansion of the Cleveland Metroparks' multi-use paths would establish the foundation for a truly comprehensive network of trails in Cuyahoga County. Communities and trail groups are also enthused about potential connections to these main arteries to provide recreational opportunities and alternative transportation choices.

Lorain County

Lorain County Metroparks, in partnership with numerous communities in the county, has developed a countywide trail and bikeway plan that envisions potential regional connections as well as connections between individual communities.

The backbone of this system is the eastern portion of the North Coast Inland Trail. The trail was first conceived in 1989 to go from Lorain County west to the outskirts of Toledo. The trail begins in Elyria and follows old railroad lands approximately 12 miles southwest through Oberlin to Kipton. It continues west

toward Toledo. Lorain County also has a number of small trail systems and planned bikeways in communities like Avon, Avon Lake, Lorain, Sheffield, Sheffield Lake, and North Ridgeville.

There are three additional corridors that have been identified in Lorain County's plan that could enhance the system. The Elyria-Medina connector would link the North Coast Inland Trail in Elyria and travel north through Grafton into Medina County along a railroad right-of-way. The Amherst-Wellington connector travels from Amherst Township south to Wellington along another railroad right-of-way. Finally, Lorain Metroparks is planning the Pony Trail from the southern portion of Amherst through the city of Lorain to Lake Erie

Medina County

A Medina County Bike/Hike Plan was completed in 2001 by a group that included the Medina County Park District, the cities of Medina, Brunswick, Wadsworth, and the Village of Seville. The plan presents a coordinated approach to the development of a multi-purpose trail system for Medina County with opportunity to provide several links to trail systems and places of interest in adjoining counties.

Portage County

A coalition of agencies and organizations in Portage County has developed an ambitious plan to develop a countywide system of multi-purpose trails that will also provide linkages to adjacent counties. The backbone of the county system is called "The Portage", an east-west corridor that will eventually link with the Western Reserve Greenway, trails operated by Metroparks Serving Summit County, and the Ohio & Erie Canal Corridor.

Many segments of "The Portage" are complete, while others are under construction or await funding. Segments have been developed in the cities of Kent and Ravenna, in Franklin Township, and by the Portage County Park District.

Stark County

The Stark County Park District spearheaded a planning process that resulted in the Stark County Trail and Greenway Plan. The Plan identifies no less than 20 existing and potential corridors that would eventually comprise an extensive countywide trail system. Major trails include the Ohio to Erie Canal corridor trails, the Sippo Valley Trail, a proposed Canton Downtown Connector Trail, the Louisville Trolley Trail, and the Mahoning Valley Trail.

Summit County

Summit County is another northeastern Ohio county that is fortunate to have its own trail and greenway plan. The Summit County Trail and Greenway Plan was guided by a multi-agency coordinating committee and received input from numerous agencies and organizations. The Plan provides a bold vision for a regional network of open spaces, cultural and natural resources linked together by public access. This planning effort was completed in two phases. Phase 1 focused on the area commonly referred to as the Canal Corridor. Phase 2, completed in 2001, focused on identifying local and regional connections throughout the county. Numerous trails are identified in the Plan as priorities for future development, including the extension of the towpath trail in downtown Akron.

The Great Ohio Lake to River Greenway

The Great Ohio Lake to River Greenway is envisioned as an approximately 100 mile-long corridor of protected open space that will connect Lake Erie at Ashtabula Harbor with the Ohio River around East Liverpool. This greenway will include trail development that will be built on railroad lands and adjacent corridors running through farmlands, woodlands, along waterways, and over gently rolling hills. Individual components of this greenway system are being protected and developed by an array of park districts, local communities and private organizations. Approximately 39 miles of trail have been built to date.

Some individual segments of the greenway are referred as the Western Reserve Greenway (Ashtabula and Trumbull counties), the Mill Creek Metroparks Bikeway (Mahoning County) and the Little Beaver Creek Greenway Trail (Columbiana County). Major uncompleted sections include a segment from Ashtabula Harbor to south of Interstate 90, sections in southern Trumbull and Mahoning counties, and major sections through Columbiana County.

Ohio & Erie Canal National Heritage Canalway

The Ohio & Erie Canal National Heritage Canalway is a 110 mile heritage greenway that primarily follows the route of the old Ohio & Erie Canal through four northeastern Ohio counties. Starting in the Cleveland Flats area near Lake Erie, the canal way includes the Cuyahoga Valley Towpath Trail, the Canalway National Scenic Byway, and the Cuyahoga Valley Scenic Railroad as it goes south through Cuyahoga, Summit, Stark and Tuscarawas counties. Along its route, numerous public agencies and private organizations have developed various segments of multi-purpose trails that serve as the spine of the canal way. These agencies work in cooperation with the non-profit Ohio & Erie Canal Corridor Coalition (OECCC) to preserve, interpret, and develop the natural, historic and recreation resources along the Ohio & Erie Canal. OECCC also works in partnership with the Cleveland-based Ohio Canal Corridor and the Ohio & Erie Canal Association, the management entity of the canal way.

Ohio to Erie Trail

The two routes of the Ohio to Erie Trail (OFT) converge in northeastern Ohio. Major sections are awaiting development in Holmes and Wayne counties (Heart of Ohio) as well as Coshocton and Tuscarawas counties (Panhandle). Completing the trail north of Harvard Avenue in Cleveland to the Flats area is

another general priority.

Tri State Trail

The Tri State Trail is a combination of existing and planned trails and shared roadway bicycle routes that will eventually link the tri-state area of Ohio, West Virginia, and Pennsylvania. Ultimately, this system would provide linkages to the Great Ohio Lake to River Greenway (and Lake Erie) and to western Pennsylvania, through the north panhandle of West Virginia to the Washington, D.C. metropolitan area.

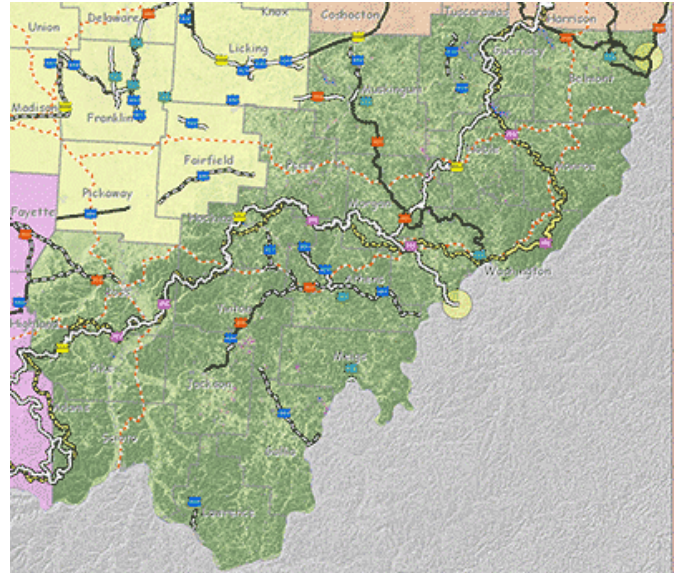
The Tri State Trail is planned as two (north and south) corridors with connecting corridors on both sides of the Ohio River (from East Liverpool to Bridgeport in Ohio). Both corridors originate in Zoarville. The North Corridor is just over 93 miles in length and will eventually connect Zoarville to Chartier's Creek, Pennsylvania. Approximately 25 percent (23 miles) of this section is constructed, including the Conotton Creek Trail in Harrison County. Over 50 percent of the North Corridor would be on shared roadways. Interstate connections are being considered on the Ft. Steuben Bridge and the Veteran Memorial Bridge.

The South Corridor is approximately 138 miles in length and will connect Zoarville to Washington, Pennsylvania. The South Corridor would follow roads south from Zoarville through Dover, New Philadelphia, Uhrichsville, and Dennison on its way to the existing National Road Bikeway in St. Clairsville. Proposed on and off-road sections would take the trail to Bridgeport where it could cross the Ohio River on the U.S. 40/250 (National Road) bridge.

SOUTHEAST OHIO

Overview

The southeast portion of Ohio is arguably the most scenic region in the state and the home of many large public land holdings that serve as major tourist attractions while providing a multitude of outdoor recreational opportunities. Virtually all of these lands have extensive systems of recreational trails. Major sections of the North Country National Scenic Trail, the American Discovery Trail and the Buckeye Trail pass through many of these public lands as they traverse southern Ohio counties and communities. There is also a possibility of someday using remaining Ohio & Erie canal lands south of Columbus to eventually connect to Portsmouth on the Ohio River.



Recreational trail development outside of traditional parks and forests is somewhat limited in southeast Ohio. This area is not as heavily populated as other regions in Ohio and there are few planning efforts aimed at developing interconnected trail systems. There are, however, some significant efforts in various stages of planning and development that will make this region an even more important recreation and tourist area.

Figure 5.10

Gallia County Hike and Bike Trail

The Gallia County Hike and Bike Trail is envisioned as a 28-mile trail along a former CSX railroad right-of-way. The trail extends south along the Ohio River Valley to the City of Gallipolis. After leaving Gallipolis, the right-of-way winds northwest through the unglaciated Appalachian foothills of Gallia and Vinton counties.

The O.O. McIntyre Park District has developed sections of the Gallia County Hike and Bike Trail. The Park District owns or has purchased easements on a majority of the 28 miles of right-of-way, although there are three small segments north of the Village of Bidwell that are not in public ownership. Future development will focus on the sections south of Bidwell.

Great Guernsey Trail

The Great Guernsey Trail is envisioned as a countywide trail system that will eventually link to other regional trail systems and the Buckeye Trail. One phase of the Great Guernsey Trail would mostly follow abandoned railroad lands from the City of Cambridge north to the Village of Kimbolton and eventually link to Salt Fork State Park. An east-west section of the Great Guernsey Trail is also proposed along a railroad right-of-way east of Interstate 77.

Hockhocking Adena Bikeway

The 17-mile Hockhocking Adena Bikeway is one of the major existing trail systems in southeastern Ohio. It follows the Old Columbus and Hocking Valley Railroad and connects the cities of Nelsonville and Athens. A unique feature of the Hockhocking Adena Bikeway is that it links Ohio University in Athens and Hocking College in Nelsonville. The City of Athens recently extended the Hockhocking Adena Bikeway with the completion of the East State Street Bikeway with plans to possibly extend the trail to Strouds Run State Park.

Muskingum River Greenway

The Muskingum River is a rich cultural and natural resource that is predominately located in southeastern Ohio. The Muskingum Valley Park District and the City of Zanesville have developed trails along the northern section of the river corridor. There is also potential to develop additional segments of recreational trail along sections of railroad right-of-way south all the way to the City of Marietta on the Ohio River. Such a trail system could eventually connect a series of locks and dams that are components of the Muskingum River State Park to the City of Marietta's Bike Trail.

Tri-County Triangle Trail

Significant segments of the Tri-County Triangle Trail are located in the southeast Ohio region. The Tri-County Triangle Trail is proposed to link three cities in three south central Ohio counties: Chillicothe in Ross County; Washington Court House in Fayette County; and Greenfield in Highland County. The Tri-County Triangle Trail will eventually provide connections to Xenia, Dayton, Cincinnati and Columbus. The Tri-County Triangle Trail is approximately 52 miles in length that will be developed primarily on abandoned railroad rights-of-way. It is a classic partnership project involving Tri-County Trail, Inc., the National Park Service, the Ross County Park District, and other local government entities.

To date, approximately one-half of the proposed 52 miles have been acquired and/or developed. Significant segments between Chillicothe and Greenfield and Greenfield and Washington Court House must still be acquired.

Tri-State Trail

The proposed southern corridor of the Tri-State Trail is located in the southeast region (see the northeast regional assessment for more information). The Tri-State Trail includes the National Road Bikeway in St. Clairsville. The proposed sections include signed shared roadways and the additional use of railroad rights-of-way. Crossing the Ohio River to connect to trail systems in West Virginia is a significant development barrier.

SOUTHWEST OHIO

Overview

Southwest Ohio is another region in the state that is characterized by extensive systems of interconnected recreational trails. For the most part, these trail systems are located in proximity to the population centers along Interstates 71 and 75, near riparian corridors, on old canal lands, and on abandoned railroad rights-of-way. Southwest Ohio is home to one of the states' first and longest rail-trails, ODNR's Little Miami State Park. The popularity of the state park helped stimulate interest in trails throughout the region. Segments of the North Country National Scenic Trail, American Discovery Trail, Buckeye Trail and Ohio to Erie Trail are also located in southwest Ohio.

Park districts and other local government agencies in southwest Ohio have been particularly active in planning and developing trails. In addition, the Miami Valley Regional Planning Commission and the Ohio Kentucky Indiana Council of Governments have been leaders for some time in bicycle and pedestrian planning and development.

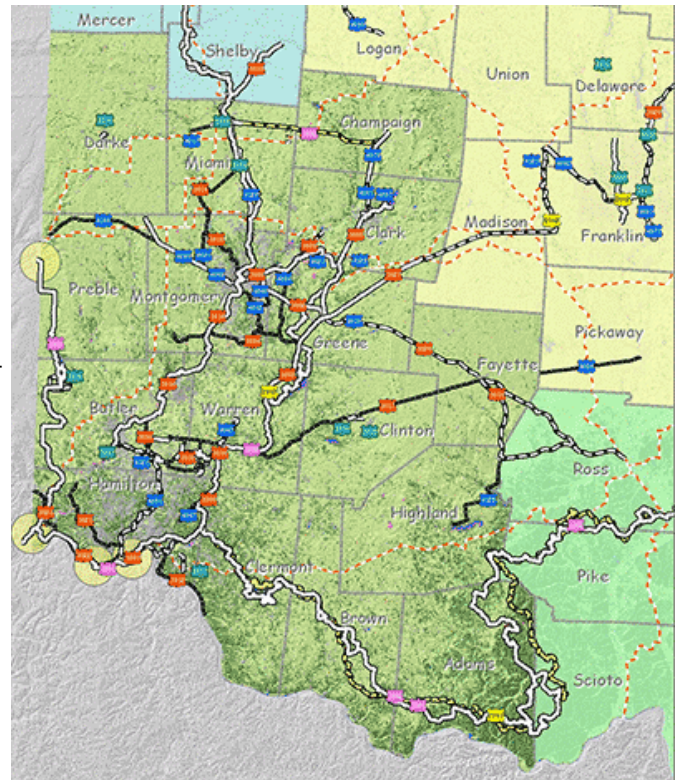


Figure 5.11

Great Miami River Trail

The Great Miami River Trail (Bikeway), as planned, would extend more than 50 miles from Fairfield north through Hamilton and Middletown in Butler County, Franklin in Warren County and eventually to Dayton. About 60 percent of the proposed trail has been completed, including 25 miles at the northern end in Dayton. In the unincorporated areas around Middletown, most of the proposed right-of-way is owned by the Miami Conservancy District and Metroparks of Butler County. An "Extend the Trail Committee" was established to oversee planning and engineering issues while local government agencies seek funds to develop remaining sections of the proposed trail.

Greene County

Greene County has been a true leader in the rail-trail movement in Ohio since the mid-1980s. More than 60 miles of former railroad rights-of-way are now available as multi-use paths. The Greene County Commissioners, the Greene County Park District, the City of Xenia and other local government agencies

have combined to develop a truly impressive network of trails that link communities, schools, churches, parks, and businesses throughout the county and to neighboring counties. Xenia Station, in the City of Xenia, is an exact replica of the original telegraph office that once occupied the same location during the railroad era. Xenia Station now serves as a hub and staging area for four major rail-trails: the Little Miami Scenic Trail, the Creekside Trail; the Ohio to Erie Trail; and the Jamestown Connector.

The Jamestown Connector is the only one of these that has not yet been completely developed. It travels east from Xenia Station to Jamestown and eventually on to Washington Court House in adjacent Fayette County where it will connect with the Tri-County Triangle Trail.

Little Miami State Park

In 1979, ODNR established a unique component in its state park system with the official designation of the Little Miami State Park (LMSP). The state park is approximately a 50-mile long linear park that parallels the Little Miami River. A paved multi-purpose trail that meanders with the river through four counties is the primary recreational development in the park. A small section of the park through the Village of Terrace Park in Hamilton County has not yet been fully developed but is open for use. Closing this gap is considered a high priority to make the LMSP a seamless trail that will eventually go to downtown Cincinnati.

The Greene County Park District has extended the trail north of Hedges Road and there is now a continuous trail all the way to Springfield in Clark County. The Hamilton County Park District, in partnership with the Anderson Township Park District and the City of Cincinnati, plans to eventually extend the trail south, linking to Cincinnati's downtown riverfront area.

Miami County

A coalition of public agencies, private organizations, and citizens has developed an ambitious conceptual plan for developing a county bikeway that would link the cities of Piqua, Troy and Tipp City and counties to the north (Shelby) and south (Montgomery). Portions of the bikeway will utilize remnants of the Miami & Erie Canal that are parallel to the Great Miami River. Various local governments, the Miami Conservancy District, and the Miami County Park District are working on completing specific segments of the bikeway. When complete, the bikeway will enable users to experience a variety of historic and cultural sites while providing recreational and transportation opportunities.

Mill Creek Greenway

In 1998, the Mill Creek Restoration Project, in partnership with an advisory committee and a team of consultants, completed the Mill Creek Greenway Master Plan. The Plan outlines a number of different projects, including trails, along 28 miles of the Mill Creek corridor from Liberty Township in Butler County south to the Ohio River. A series of connecting trails between the Mill Creek and nearby communities are also proposed to provide recreation and transportation alternatives. A partnership of local communities, state and federal agencies, businesses, and citizens will work with the Mill Creek Restoration Project to implement the recommendations in the Master Plan.

Montgomery County

Montgomery County is fortunate to have over 60 miles of multi-use trails throughout the county. These trails have been built and are maintained by the Miami Conservancy District, Five Rivers MetroParks, the City of Dayton and other local communities in the county. Many of these trails have been built in riparian corridors and provide direct linkages to communities, parks, adjacent counties, and other areas of interest.

Ohio River Trail

Local officials have planned a bike/hike trail along the Ohio River corridor since the early 1970s. The Ohio River Trail includes both east and western riverfront segments and will eventually stretch to New Richmond in Clermont County. The Riverfront East Bike Trail would start at the central riverfront in downtown Cincinnati and connect to the Lunken Bike Trail where it could intersect with the Little Miami Scenic Trail as it makes its way north through Anderson Township to Milford. From Lunken Airport the trail would also continue east approximately 16 miles through Anderson Township to New Richmond. The Western Riverfront Trail would ultimately extend to Shawnee Lookout Park.

A formal planning committee was established and is coordinating the Ohio River Trail project. The committee raised money for a feasibility study to determine the trail's alignment. A formal route was recommended and future funding options are now being explored.

Tri-County Triangle Trail

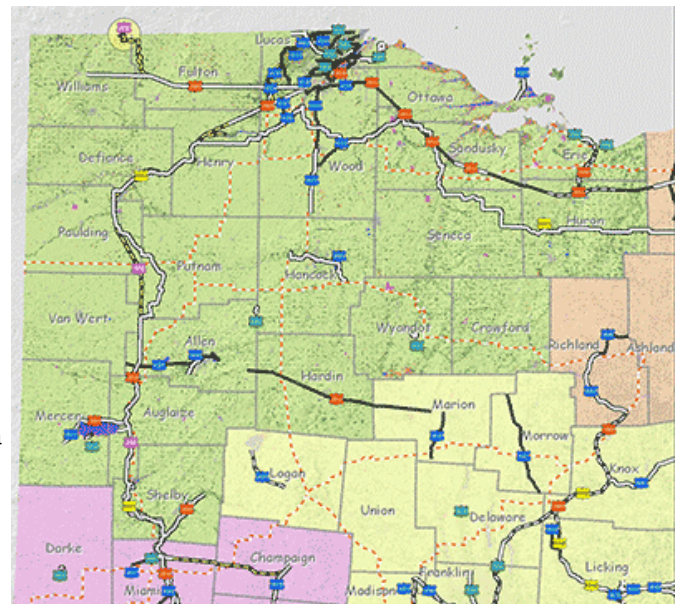
Two of the three counties (Highland and Fayette) that form the basis of the Tri-County Triangle Trail are located in the southwest region (see southeast regional assessment for more information). A segment from the Fayette/Ross County line into Washington Court House is scheduled for development in the near future. Major sections of the planned trail from Washington Court House south to Greenfield must still be acquired.

NORTHWEST OHIO

Overview

With a few exceptions, northwest Ohio is a sparsely populated region that is dominated by intensive agricultural land use. There are, however, some significant trail and greenway initiatives in this region that involve development on the remains of the Miami & Erie Canal, abandoned railroads, and along riparian corridors. In addition, the Toledo Metropolitan Area Council of Governments has established a Pedestrian and Bikeway Committee that is actively pursuing the development of a comprehensive, interconnected network of bicycle and pedestrian facilities in the Toledo-Lucas County region and adjacent counties.

Major segments of the Miami & Erie Canal are still in public ownership in northwest Ohio. Many of these old canal lands are the foundation for the North Country National Scenic Trail, the Buckeye Trail, ODNR's Miami & Erie Canal Towpath Trail, and trail systems operated by the Metropark District of the Toledo Area and other local agencies. The North Coast Inland Trail, the Wabash Cannonball Trail, and the Slippery Elm Trail are long distance rail-trails in the region. The Hancock Park District (Heritage Trail ? Blanchard River) and City of Lima (Ottawa River Trail) are developing important trail networks along river corridors in their respective jurisdictions.



Heritage Trail

The Heritage Trail covers about 20 miles along the Blanchard River in Hancock County. The western trailhead is located near Litzenberg Memorial Woods. The trail travels east toward downtown Findlay along the river corridor. Along its way the trail connects various parks, historic sites, reservoirs and other landmarks with a variety of trail surfaces and in different settings. Users can experience both rustic, natural environments as well as urban conditions along paved bike paths and downtown Findlay Riverwalks. The Hancock Park District and the City of Findlay are still developing specific segments of the Heritage Trail in partnership with various businesses and volunteer groups.

Lucas County

Lucas County has an extensive network of existing and planned recreational trails and bike routes that, when completed, will service virtually all areas of the county. Connections to adjacent counties are also envisioned. Under the leadership of TMACOG's Pedestrian and Bikeway Committee, a bicycle/trails plan has been integrated into the council's regional transportation plan. The plan identifies a number of trails and connecting spurs that will be priorities for future development. These include the University Parks Trail, the Wabash Cannonball Trail, the North Coast Inland Trail, the Swan Creek Green Space Trail, the Ottawa River Green Space Trail, the Oregon-East Toledo-Perrysburg Trail, the Portage River Trail, the Buckeye Trail, and the North Country National Scenic Trail.

Miami & Erie Canal

Major segments of the old towpath of the Miami & Erie Canal remain intact in Northwest Ohio. Although the canal lands represent a very narrow corridor of public ownership, they provide an almost continuous route for a trail where little other opportunities exist. This is especially true between Delphos in Allen County and Lockington in southern Shelby County. ODNR is responsible for a 40 mile segment that is managed as the Miami & Erie Canal Trail.

North of Delphos, large intact sections of the canal are still in public ownership in Putnam, Paulding, Defiance, Henry, and Lucas counties. Two state parks, Mary Jane Thurston and Independence Dam, have remnants of the old canal. The Metropark District of the Toledo Area manages four other parks that have remnants of canal lands in Lucas County.

A future priority will be to find viable public agencies to protect and manage the remaining canal lands in northwest Ohio. The Miami-Erie Canal Corridor Association (MECCA) is a non-profit organization created in 1996 to champion the cause of the Miami & Erie Canal. MECCA focuses most of its attention on a 55 mile stretch of publicly owned canal lands from Delphos to Piqua. MECCA's goal is to raise awareness of the historical, education, natural and recreational value of the canal and serve as a clearinghouse for information for canal related events and information. MECCA also works to strengthen canal partnerships and supports the designation of the canal as a national heritage corridor.

North Coast Inland Trail

The North Coast Inland Trail was first conceived as a regional rail-trail in 1989 that was planned to go from the east side of Toledo to Lorain County. There are now plans to possibly extend the trail to cover an entire east-west route that would eventually link Pennsylvania, Michigan, and Indiana through northern Ohio.

Significant segments of the original North Coast Inland Trail must still be acquired and/or developed. A major gap exists in Huron County where major sections of the right-of-way are in public ownership but trail development has been delayed. A 10 mile section between Fremont and Elmore is awaiting development while another section in northwest Ottawa County must still be acquired. A coalition of park districts and other government entities in northwest Ohio is working to acquire and develop remaining sections of the North Coast Inland Trail.

Wabash Cannonball Trail

The Wabash Cannonball Trail is envisioned as a more than 60-mile multi-use rail-trail to accommodate bikers, bicyclists, equestrians, inline skaters, and cross-country skiers. The Wabash Cannonball Trail is one of Ohio's longest rail-trails in four Ohio counties-Fulton, Henry, Lucas, and Williams. The trail is actually comprised of two rail lines that converge in Maumee at Jerome Road. The "North Fork" runs east-west for 46 miles from Maumee to within 15 miles of the Indiana state line near Montpelier. The "South Fork" takes a southwesterly direction from Maumee for 17 miles to the edge of Liberty Center in Henry County.

The landowning partners ? Lucas County, City of Maumee, City of Wauseon, the Village of Whitehouse, the Metropark District of the Toledo Area, and the Northwestern Ohio Rails-to-Trails Association ? are all developing and maintaining different segments of the Wabash Cannonball Trail. The trail will have both paved and unpaved sections. Portions of the trail are certified segments of the North Country National Scenic Trail and a spur from the Wabash is envisioned as providing an eventual link to the state of Michigan.

CENTRAL OHIO

Overview

Recreational trail planning and development in the central Ohio region has been a mixed bag. Government agencies and trail advocates in Franklin and Licking counties in particular have been leaders while efforts in many other central Ohio counties have lagged or met significant opposition. The cross-state Ohio to Erie Trail passes through the central Ohio region and completing the trail through Columbus and Franklin County has been a significant challenge (see narrative on Ohio to Erie Trail). Knox County is the home of the popular Kokosing Gap and Mohican Valley trails and there are plans to develop additional connections to adjacent counties. Interest in trail development has also intensified in Lancaster (Fairfield County) with the Heritage Trail network while agencies in Delaware, Logan and Pickaway counties are exploring trail networks.

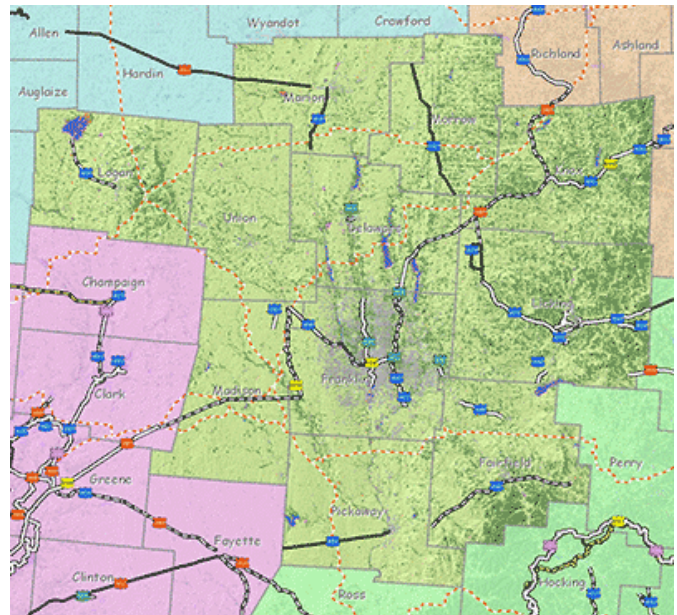


Figure 5.16

Franklin County

The Mid-Ohio Regional Planning Commission (MORPC) has completed two significant planning efforts in recent years that have significant recreational trail implications. The Franklin County Greenways Plan was a multi-jurisdictional planning effort aimed at preserving and protecting stream corridors in central Ohio. The Greenways Plan included recommendations for developing interconnected recreational trails within river corridors and acquiring scenic easements whenever possible. In 1999, the planning commission updated its regional bicycle and pedestrian plan to provide a planning guide for local jurisdictions to develop an integrated regional bikeway network in central Ohio.

The City of Columbus has long been a leader in recreational trail development in central Ohio. Since the late 1960s, Columbus has been developing trails along riparian corridors, with primary investments along the Scioto and Olentangy Rivers. In more recent years, trail planning and development along Alum and Blacklick creeks and I-670 has been a priority.

Community trail systems are also commonplace in many central Ohio areas, especially suburban communities in Franklin County. Most of these systems satisfy the recreational and transportation needs of the individual cities by providing opportunities close to home. They may follow a single route or include a more complex network of interconnected paths and trails. In some cases, community trails may connect with countywide or regional trail systems. In addition to their recreation facilities, community trail systems can provide valuable alternative transportation opportunities by encouraging residents to bicycle or walk to work, shop, run errands, or visit family and friends. Communities in central Ohio that have or are developing extensive local systems include Dublin, Gahanna, Grove City, New Albany, Reynoldsburg, Westerville, and Worthington.

Licking County

There are almost 40 miles of recreational trails throughout Licking County. They range from the more than 14 mile Thomas J. Evans rail-trail that connects Johnstown to Newark to the four mile Blackhand Gorge

bikeway along the Licking River in the Blackhand Gorge State Nature Preserve east of Newark. Many of the trails in Licking County are vital components of the Panhandle route of the Ohio to Erie Trail as it makes its way to northeastern Ohio on to Cleveland. Completing the connection with Johnstown to Centerburg (Knox County) is a priority. Connecting the trail to downtown Newark is another priority.

The Thomas J. Evans Foundation has been a driving force in developing Licking County's trail system by providing leadership and financial assistance to many of the trail projects in the county. The Licking County Park District, the Licking County Commissioners, and the cities of Newark and Heath have also made major contributions by developing and maintaining these trails.

INTERSTATE LINKAGES

Trails, both existing and planned, that connect Ohio to its neighboring states and beyond are important components of Ohio's trail system. The concept of linking states and regions of the country has been an overall vision of trail planners and advocates for years and was given heightened consideration in 1987 when the President's Commission on Americans Outdoors recommended the creation of a national network of greenways.

The two national trails--North Country National Scenic Trail and the American Discovery Trail-- that pass through Ohio provide a number of interstate connections. Local interstate initiatives are more limited although there are several ongoing efforts to connect to neighboring states. See Table 5.1 for a summary of existing and potential interstate connections and Figure 5.17 for a graphic representation of these linkages.

Table 5.1				
Existing/Potential Interstate Linkages				
County	Trail/Route	Adjacent State	Status/Comments	
1 Ashtabula	Pymatuning Valley Greenway	Pennsylvania	A 19.5 mile undeveloped railroad right-of-way owned by Ashtabula County Parks from Dorsett, OH to Jamestown, PA	
2 Mahoning	Stavich Trail	Pennsylvania	Existing paved rail-trail approximately 12 miles long in Ohio and Pennsylvania	
3 Columbiana	North Country National Scenic Trail	Pennsylvania	Enters Ohio from Pennsylvania on former Montown railroad grade which ends near Fredricktown, OH.	
4 Jefferson	Tri State Trail	West Virginia	Option #1, Ft. Steuben Bridge	
5 Jefferson	Tri-State Trail	West Virginia	Option #2, new bridge at Brilliant	
6 Belmont	Tri State Trail	West Virginia	Option #3, National Road, U.S. 40/250 Wheeling Suspension Bridge	
7 Washington	American Discovery Trail (U.S. 50 Bridge)	West Virginia	Crosses Ohio River at Parkersburg, WV to Belpre, OH on the U.S. 50 Bridge	
8 Hamilton	American Discovery Trail (Roebing Suspension Bridge)	Kentucky	Very small section of ADT in Kentucky	
9 Hamilton	American Discovery Trail (Anderson Ferry)	Kentucky	Very small section of ADT in Kentucky	
10 Hamilton	American Discovery Trail	Indiana	Enters Indiana near Elizabethtown on Stateline Road	
11 Preble	American Discovery Trail	Indiana	Enters Indiana east of Richmond on Stateline Road	
12 Williams	North Country National Scenic Trail	Michigan	A not yet identified route that will connect the NCNST to Michigan	

POTENTIAL TRAIL CORRIDORS, OPPORTUNITIES FOR THE FUTURE

Many types of trails, pathways, waterways and routes make up Ohio's trail system. There are numerous opportunities to expand this trail system by preserving corridors and developing rights-of-way and other lands that can support trails. Railroads, canal lands, utility corridors, highway rights-of way, riparian corridors, and easements on private lands are examples of resources that trail planners and managers should consider when planning trail systems.

Railroad Rights-of-Way

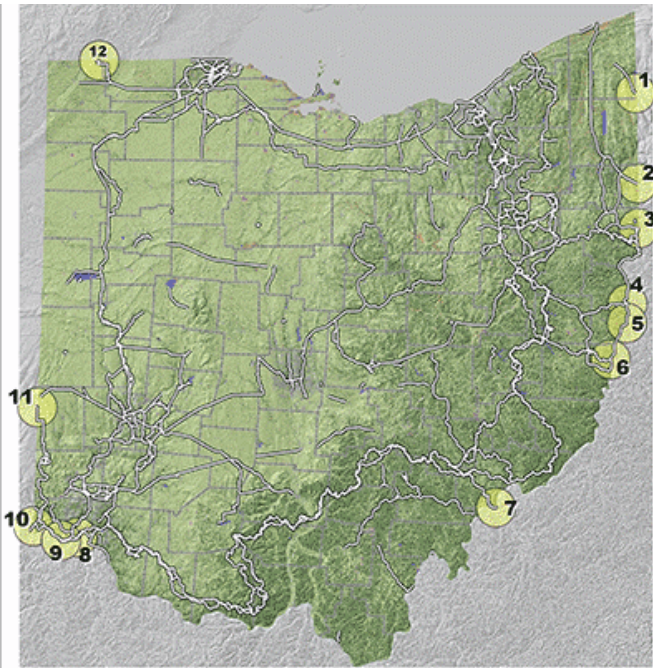


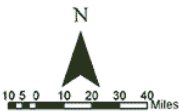
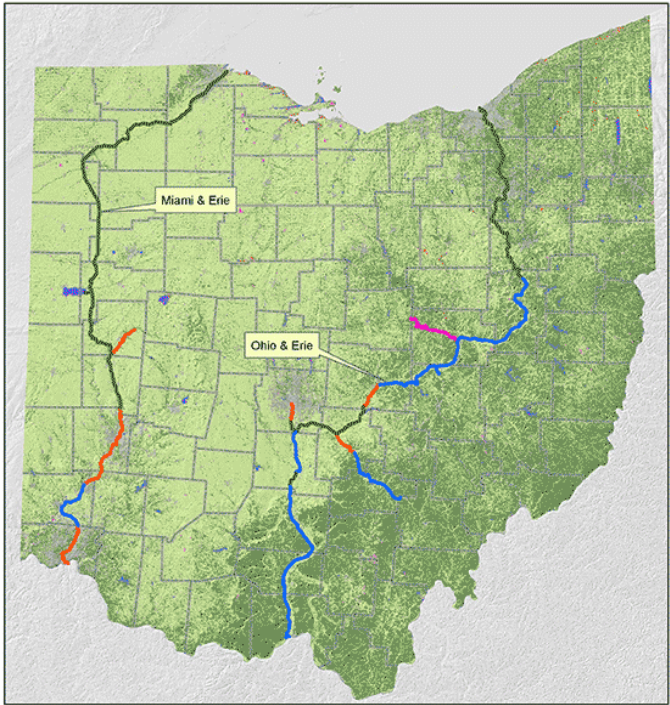
Figure 5.17 Interstate Linkages

Abandoned railroad rights-of-way are particularly well suited for trail development and Ohio is recognized as one of the national leaders in the "rail trail" movement. In fact, Ohio now has more than 50 developed rail-trails encompassing more than 700 miles. Another 600 miles are planned throughout the state. Railroad corridors usually have manageable grades and subsurface conditions are very conducive to developing multi-use trails. Although not every railroad abandonment is suitable for trail use, many segments already link population centers and parks. These corridors can also provide alternate transportation opportunities and serve as the backbone for regional and statewide trails systems.

According to the Ohio Department of Transportation, more than 6,800 miles of railroads have been abandoned in Ohio and many more continue to be abandoned each year. To date, only a fraction of these corridors have been converted to trail use. Most have been converted to highways, agriculture, or been sold to private interests. Rail abandonment begins when a railroad formally relinquishes its authority to operate a rail line and petitions to allow it to discontinue rail service along that rail line.

There are numerous issues associated with railroad abandonment that public agencies must grapple with in an effort to maximize opportunities for future trail development. Railroad corridors typically involve a complex array of ownership patterns. The railroad company could own outright portions of some segments and have only restricted use, through easements, on others. Reversionary clauses, which cause ownership to revert to original or adjacent landowners in case of abandonment, have created many legal issues in Ohio and nationally. In addition to land ownership disputes, issues like funding the purchase of the land, coordinating planning among different political jurisdictions, and winning the support of adjacent landowners have been challenges in developing more rail-trails.

An alternative to losing railroad corridors through abandonment is to preserve the

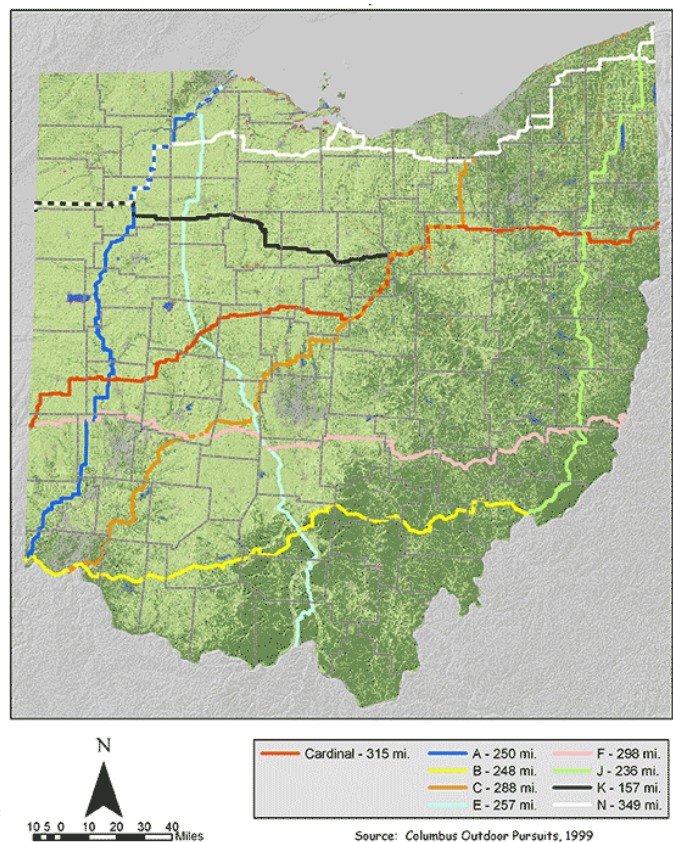


- Legend**
- Majority Public Ownership - Existing Trail or Trail Potential
 - Some Public Ownership - Limited Trail Potential
 - Some Public/Private Ownership - Parcels Intermittent
 - Majority Private Ownership - Virtually No Trail Potential
- Source: Ohio Department of Natural Resources, 2004

Historic Canals

corridor through "railbanking." Railbanking is an agreement between the railroad company and a public agency or trail group whereby the corridor, bridges, culverts, etc. remain intact for future transportation purposes. In the interim, the corridor can be developed into a trail if an agency or trail group agrees to manage the trail and cover all associated costs like taxes and liability.

Trails can also be developed adjacent to active rail lines. "Rails with trails" present some additional design and safety challenges but do represent a viable option for trail development. The Rails-to-Trails Conservancy, a national nonprofit organization with a state chapter in Ohio, is an excellent source of information and technical assistance on all facets of acquiring and developing rail-trails.



Cross State Bike Routes

Canal Lands

Canals played a significant role in the development and growth of Ohio. While major segments of these historic resources no longer exist, many have already been converted to trail use and there are numerous additional opportunities to utilize remaining canal resources for trail and greenway development. In addition to trail and greenway potential, canal lands can provide diverse environmental, historic, and cultural benefits to Ohio and its citizens.

In northeast Ohio, the Ohio & Erie Canal was the impetus for the creation of a National Heritage Corridor. The Ohio & Erie Canal National Heritage Canalway stretches approximately 110 miles from the Cleveland lakefront to New Philadelphia in Tuscarawas County. A towpath trail has been developed on the old canal lands and this trail serves as the backbone of the canal way. Similarly, remnants of the Miami & Erie Canal in western Ohio are key components of various local, regional, statewide and national trail systems like ODNR's Miami-Erie Trail, the Buckeye Trail, and the North Country National Scenic Trail. Significant portions of the Miami & Erie Canal remain from approximately the Miami-Shelby County line all the way north to Toledo in Lucas County. A diverse group of public agencies and private interests is actively working to preserve, manage, and interpret remaining canal lands on both the Ohio & Erie and the Miami & Erie. These efforts are spearheaded by the Ohio and Erie Canal Corridor Coalition and the Miami and Erie Canal Corridor Association, respectively.

Reusing historic canals for trails and preserving them for other benefits has a number of obstacles and challenges. Many segments are fragmented, making interconnections difficult. Long, intact sections are somewhat limited and finding viable public agencies or trail groups to develop and/or manage the remaining canal lands is sometimes problematic. Numerous encroachments and political realities also threaten the integrity of canal lands. ODNR owns many of the remaining segments of Ohio's historic canals that are in public ownership and have trail potential. Many other sections have been transferred to either public agencies or non-profit organizations for recreation and/or historic preservation. Where there are opportunities to provide viable trails, to connect to existing trails, or preserve other canal features, these corridors should be preserved by ODNR in partnership with other government agencies, trail groups, and historic preservation interest groups.

Utility Corridors

Public and private utility corridors can provide opportunities for new off-road trails and also provide linkages to existing trails and greenways. By definition trails are linear corridors so they can logically utilize the same corridor with utilities such as electric/power lines, water/sewer lines, television and fiber optic cable, gas lines, etc. Utility corridors could be especially attractive in urban or heavily developed areas where open space and other trail development options are limited. In many cases, overlapping trails and utilities is a way to establish both systems at less expense than providing both functions separately.

Many utilities are located on land not actually owned by the utility companies but use easements. As a result, permission of property owners to use a corridor for any use other than that for which an easement was originally designated would be required. In the case of some utilities, there could be concerns about

liability and other perceived safety issues such as electric magnetic fields emanating from power lines. Trail advocates and public agencies should work with utility providers to negotiate trail easements and promote the positive public benefits that trails will create.

Street/Road Rights-of-Way

The state of Ohio has a tremendous capital investment in its transportation infrastructure and road networks. These linear networks and associated lands can provide opportunities to accommodate trail users and link/connect to off-road trails. As a result, transportation agencies and planners should give heightened consideration to integrating trail related developments in roadway planning, construction, or renovation.

The shared use of roads and highway rights-of-way for trails presents many opportunities and challenges alike to planners. Trail improvements within a road/highway corridor could be a separate path, a bike lane (paved shoulder) with edge striping and signage, a signed roadway, or streets/roadways with bicycle designations that are open to bicycle travel and shared with other vehicles. Variables such as traffic volume, width of the right-of-way, the number and type of users, design factors, cost, and maintenance must be taken into account when considering trail development options.

Low volume or lightly traveled roads generally present the best options for potential trail segments. In fact, the Ohio Department of Transportation has nine designated cross state bicycle routes totaling more than 2,100 miles that utilize existing road and highway rights-of-way. Furthermore, the Buckeye Trail utilizes low volume county and township roads for much of its nearly 1,300 miles in Ohio. Many parts of rural Ohio have unpaved roads that could be suitable for hiking, off-road bicycles, or motorized recreation vehicles. In urban areas, systems of bicycle routes based on a shared road system can provide vital connections and linkages to off road trails. The safety of trail users is an obvious concern when highway corridors are used for recreation purposes. In general, Ohio law allows the public to use public thoroughfares by the mode of their choice but they are prohibited from bicycling and walking on freeways. For some trail activities, permission to use public rights-of-way for recreational use could be required.

Riparian Corridors

Ohio is a water rich state that is blessed with more than 60,000 miles of streams. As they wind their way through virtually all rural and urban landscapes, riparian lands and their waters can provide a multitude of opportunities for various types of trail development. In fact, many Ohio communities are actively pursuing efforts to preserve their stream corridors and many of these efforts are complimented by recreational trail development. These linear parks or corridors of protected open space are sometimes referred to as greenways. It should be noted however, that trails and greenways are not synonymous and not all greenways are in riparian corridors. Greenways are typically defined as corridors of open space that are managed for conservation or recreation while trails are paths that provide recreation and transportation alternatives. Often, however, greenways do have a trail or recreation component.

Another possibility for recreational trail development in riparian corridors involves the utilization of flood control levees. Flood control levees were constructed in many Ohio communities years ago to provide protection from advancing flood waters. Because of their linear nature and public ownership, these levees can be viable options for establishing trail systems or connecting trails.

Waterways are also being increasingly recognized as a resource for providing water-based trails. With over 1,700 miles of navigable streams in Ohio there are numerous opportunities to develop a system of water trails and access points that will provide small boat paddling routes and other recreation and conservation benefits. ODNR, in partnership with other agencies and organizations, recently initiated a Discover Ohio Water Trails planning process that will result in a blueprint to improve access to Ohio's streams and the identification of a system of state water trails.

Easements

Easements are another long-term option available to land managers for trail development where outright land ownership is not feasible. An easement is a legally binding agreement in which a landowner allows certain land uses to another party who holds the easement and enforces its terms and conditions. Easements are part of a property's deed and survive ownership transfers.

In a state like Ohio, where approximately 95 percent of the land is in private ownership, easements can be a viable option to locate and/or connect to trails. An easement could allow a landowner to provide a trail while still retaining ownership. If the land on which there is an easement is sold, the easement passes to the new landowner, thus ensuring ongoing access to a trail. The agency or organization that holds the easement is responsible for monitoring and enforcing its provisions and should maintain a good working relationship with the property owner to prevent violations. The easement can be dissolved only by the party who has been granted access thorough the easement.